

ASSAM RELINKED

Partition had left Assam isolated, flanked by a hostile East Pakistan at one end and Nepal on the other. As India adjusted to its new-formed freedom, it undertook a massive operation, to relink Assam by rail, while bridging turbulent rivers and navigating dense forests. It would be one of the Indian Railways' most outstanding engineering achievements.



▲ **The bridge over the River Tista** was one of the most difficult ones to build due to strong currents and high waves.

Partition left Assam connected to India by a strip of land a mere 20 km wide. Meanwhile, the only line of communication between India and West Bengal's northern districts of Darjeeling and Jalpaiguri was a 2-ft-gauge line with limited capacity. Relinking Assam, the gateway to the north-east and crucial to Indian interests, had become a matter of urgency. As a Ministry of Railways memorandum to the Cabinet noted, it was an "absolute necessity both strategically and administratively. India cannot depend for passage to Assam on the goodwill of Pakistan."